Portfolio Projects for BUSINESS COMMUNICATIONS

Chapter 6

Messages with Negative News



Objectives

- Use persuasive techniques in a refusal letter
- Structure a refusal letter
- Write complaint letters
- Reply to complaint letters
- Create envelopes in Word
- Create labels in Word

Introduction

- Messages that communicate negative news communicate unwelcome information to the reader
  - A form of persuasive correspondence
- When writing a message with negative news, retain reader goodwill and persuade them to accept the news as fair and reasonable

Messages with Negative News Essentials

- You spent many weeks putting together a proposal
- Weeks later you receive the following letter

Negative News (cont'd.)

Birch County Planning Committee
3409 West Mall, Kansas City, KS 66104
Phone: (913) 555-1066
www.birchcountykansas.com

September 12, 2011

Applicant
100 Maple Drive
Kansas City, KS 66112

Dear Applicant:

We regret to inform you that your proposal to build a new playground at Birch Drive Elementary School has been rejected.

We receive many proposals such as yours. While your proposal had merit, the funding committee cannot approve it. Consider applying again next year. Good luck.

Sincerely,

Planning Committee

Figure 6-1 Poorly structured refusal letter

Negative News (cont'd.)

- Do you feel angry? Upset? Deflated?
- Messages with negative news should not evoke these emotions
  - You will feel a certain amount of disappointment
  - If message is written well, you should not feel angry or upset

Negative News (cont'd.)

- Poorly structured refusal letter:
  - Impersonal
  - Abruptly states the rejection
  - Did not provide helpful information
  - Was not friendly
  - Not signed properly

Negative News (cont'd.)

- Using persuasive techniques in the refusal letter
  - Sales letters persuade reader to buy a product or service
    - Refusal letters persuade reader to accept that the refusal is fair and reasonable
  - Help the reader accept the negative news
    - If appropriate, determine how they could receive a letter of acceptance at another time

Negative News (cont'd.)

- Using persuasive techniques in the refusal letter (cont'd.)
  - Try to identify with reader's feelings and goals
    - They are hoping for good news, but worry about receiving bad news
    - **Let the reader down slowly, clarify the reason, and provide an alternative**

Negative News (cont'd.)

- Structuring a refusal letter
  - Structure according to level of **emotional investment** the reader has in receiving a positive response
  - If **neutral, use the direct approach**
    - Reader does not need to be led slowly because they have little emotional investment
    - **State refusal in first sentence** or two and close positively

Negative News (cont'd.)

- Structuring a refusal letter (cont'd.)
  - If **refusal might have an emotional impact** use the persuasive refusal structure
    - Consists of five paragraphs

Negative News (cont'd.)

Paragraph	Analysis
Paragraph 1: Thank you	• In the first sentence, thank the reader for the contact. • In the second sentence, build goodwill with the reader: be polite but not effusive.
Paragraph 2: Context	• Provide the reader with the rationale behind the decision. • Present information neutrally as you build toward the refusal. • Provide the reader with the opportunity to anticipate the *no* before you actually state it. • Present the context for the refusal in a fair and reasonable way.
Paragraph 3: No	• Say no clearly, but diplomatically and without using any negative words. Note that you can use *not* when you pair it with a positive word such as *not accepted* instead of *rejected*.
Paragraph 4: Positive alternative	• Provide some hope in the form of a positive alternative.
Paragraph 5: Positive close	• Thank the reader again and then provide your contact information, if appropriate.

Figure 6-2 Five-paragraph structure for a refusal letter

Negative News (cont'd.)

Birch County Planning Committee
3409 West Mall, Kansas City, KS 66104
Phone: (913) 555-1066
www.birchcountyplanning.com

September 12, 2011

Mary-Lou Bennett
100 Maple Drive
Kansas City, KS 66112

paragraph 1: thank the reader for the contact

Dear Ms. Bennett:

Thank you for submitting your proposal to build a new playground at Birch Drive Elementary School. We appreciate the effort you put into writing the proposal.

paragraph 2: provide the context for the refusal

The Birch County Planning Committee receives many proposals every year from community groups and individuals. We value the dedication and community experience of these proposals and are looking to increase our funding so that we can accept many more proposal than we are able to at present. This year, we were able to accept three proposals out of the 100 proposals we received. All three of these proposals addressed issues related to safety and security in our community.

paragraph 3: say no politely and respectfully

Your proposal for a new playground had great merit. However, our focus this year is on safety concerns. As a result, we are not able to accept your proposal.

paragraph 4: provide a positive alternative

Next year, our funding is predicted to increase by 30%. We also may be in a position to consider more proposals related to children in our community if we receive funds from a new government initiative. We would be delighted if you would reapply next year.

paragraph 5: close positively

Thank you, Ms. Bennett, for sharing your proposal with the Birch County Planning Committee. If you require information about how to apply next year, please check out our Web site at www.birchcountyplanning.com.

Sincerely,

Martha Friesen
Director: Birch County Planning Committee

Figure 6-3
Effective refusal letter

Complaint letter

- Writing a complaint letter
  - Generally written because writer is angry and upset about poor service or a defective product
  - Purpose is to state exactly what the company can do to address the situation
  - Use a positive, respectful tone, include details about the problem, and state expected compensation clearly

Jack Danvers
1800 Cantrell Drive, Little Rock, AR 72207
Phone: (501) 555-7781/e-mail: jackdanvers@earthsource.com

March 10, 2011

General Manager
Blue Heron Resort
82400 South Highway
Everglades City, FL 33037

Dear Sir/Madam:

I must complain about the noise at your hotel when I stayed there recently. I was looking forward to a relaxing vacation and the vacation I got was anything but relaxing.

Trouble began when my family and I went to bed the first night. Apparently, there was a soccer team in town and they were on the same floor with us. Well let me tell you, they partied all night long. I have small children and they could not even go to sleep because there was so much noise!!! I called the front desk and they told me to deal with it – because it was only 10:00 p.m. even though the noise went on long into the night.

I feel that the front desk staff needed to be more understanding of our situation. The other guests should have been asked to quiet down IMMEDIATELY. The front desk staff should have offered us another room on a different floor. Well, thank goodness, the team left in the morning and we did not hear from them again.

The remainder of our vacation was OK, although the view from our room was not as spectacular as your brochures led us to expect. Also, the weather was poor.

I am requesting a full week's free stay at your hotel the next time my family and I visit Florida. Thank you.

Sincerely,

Jack Danvers

date of the stay is not specified

negative words antagonize the reader

complaint about the weather is irrelevant

requested compensation is unreasonable

Figure 6-4
Ineffective complaint letter

Complaint letter: Structure

Paragraph	Analysis
Paragraph 1: Context for the complaint	• State that you have a concern with the service or product and specify when and where you made the purchase.
Paragraph 2: Details about the complaint	• Use neutral language to describe the problem as precisely as possible.
Paragraph 3: Compensation expected	• Provide additional details, if necessary, and then state exactly what compensation you require.
Paragraph 4: Positive close	• Provide contact information and close positively.

Figure 6-5 Four-paragraph structure for a complaint letter

Jack Danvers
1800 Cantrell Drive, Little Rock, AR 72207
Phone: (501) 555-7781/e-mail: jackdanvers@earthsource.com

March 10, 2011

Rhonda Harris
General Manager
Blue Heron Resort
82400 South Highway
Everglades City, FL 33037

Dear Ms. Harris:

My family and I stayed at your resort from March 2 to March 8, 2011. You advertise the resort as family friendly, and so I would like to draw your attention to a situation that was not up to the standards we expected.

1. Neutral opening states the date and the issue

On our first night at your resort, our two young children were not able to sleep because members of a soccer team staying on our floor were having a very loud party. I called the front desk every hour starting at 10:00 p.m. and requested that the team's coach or hotel security ask the team members to be more respectful of the other guests. However, the noise continued at the same level until 4:00 a.m.

2. Details of the complaint are presented clearly and without malice

The front desk staff needed to be much more understanding of our situation. We have small children who need to sleep if they are to enjoy the next day's activities. As a result of this incident, I would not wish to recommend your resort to others as family friendly.

3. The required compensation is stated clearly

I am requesting a refund of our first night's stay at your resort on Saturday, March 2nd. Thank you for your attention to my concerns. If you wish to discuss this matter further, please call me in Little Rock at (501) 555-7781.

4. Closing is polite and businesslike

Sincerely,

Jack Danvers

Figure 6-6 Effective complaint letter

Complaint letter: Tone

- Writing a complaint letter (cont'd.)
  - Focus on **effect it will have on the reader**
  - Use a **neutral tone to state the complaint** and **request reasonable compensation**
  - **Avoid negative words**
    - Exception: "not" when used with a positive (e.g., *We were not pleased*…)

Replying to complaint letter

- Replying to a complaint letter
  - Determine what the reader wants
    - **Acknowledgment**
    - **Compensation**
  - Replying to a complaint letter is challenging if you are unable to give the requested compensation

Reply: Structure

Paragraph	Analysis
Paragraph 1: Context for the complaint	• Thank the reader for informing you about the issue. Clearly describe the writer's concern as you understand it and avoid negative words such as *problem*; include an apology if appropriate.
Paragraph 2: Details about the complaint	• Describe the situation with the aim of leading the reader to recognize that the requested compensation cannot be granted.
Paragraph 3: Compensation offered	• Describe the compensation that can be granted; instead of describing what you cannot do, describe what you can do.
Paragraph 4: Positive close	• Close positively with a request to the reader to contact you if further clarification is required.

Figure 6-7 Structure for a reply to a complaint letter

Blue Heron Resort

82400 South Highway, Everglades City, FL 33037
Phone: (305) 555-9987/Fax: (305) 555-9984
Web site: www.floridablueheronresort.com

March 15, 2011

Mr. Jack Danvers
1800 Cantrell Drive
Little Rock, AR 72207

Dear Mr. Danvers:

Thank you for your letter of March 10 describing your experience while staying at Blue Heron Resort with your family from March 2 to March 8, 2011. I understand your concern about the noise issue.

Blue Heron Resort prides itself on its excellent customer service and family friendly atmosphere. As a result, I am very concerned to learn that our front desk staff did not sufficiently address your concerns. Please be assured that we are taking steps to improve the quality of all front staff services. Your comfort as our guests at Blue Heron Resort is our top priority. We want to be sure that all families feel welcomed and rested here. In fact, we have designated "quiet" floors that families with young children can choose to ensure the peace and quiet of their vacation. As a result of your letter, we will be asking anyone making a reservation if they would like a "quiet" floor. Your feedback is helping us improve our customer relations.

The next time you come to Blue Heron Resort with your family, we will be pleased to offer you a complimentary night's accommodation in a Queen suite similar to the suite you enjoyed in March. We will also ensure that the suite is on one of our designated "quiet" floors.

Mr. Danvers, please call me at (305) 555-9987 to reserve your complimentary night's stay at Blue Heron Resort. We look forward to welcoming you again.

Sincerely,

Rhonda Harris
General Manager

1. Thank the reader, briefly restate the concerns, and offer an apology if appropriate

2. Provide details and solutions

3. State the compensation that is offered

4. Close positively

Figure 6-8 Reply to an unreasonable complaint letter

Mr. Jack Danvers
1800 Cantrell Drive
Little Rock, AR 72207

Dear Mr. Danvers:

Thank you for your letter of March 10 describing your experience while staying at Blue Heron Resort with your family from March 2 to March 8, 2011. I am pleased to send you the refund you requested. The check is enclosed. I am also enclosing a $50 certificate, which you can use for room service, in one of our fine restaurants, or at our gift shop during your next visit.

Blue Heron Resort prides itself on its excellent customer service and family friendly atmosphere. As a result, I am very concerned to learn that our front desk staff did not sufficiently address your concerns. Please be assured that we are taking steps to improve the quality of all front staff services. Your comfort as our guests at Blue Heron Resort is our top priority. We want to be sure that all families feel welcomed and rested here.

Mr. Danvers, please call me at (305) 555-9987 when you are ready to reserve your next vacation at Blue Heron Resort. We look forward to welcoming you again.

Figure 6-9 Positive reply to a reasonable complaint letter

Practice session

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